

BEFORE

When Nicholas II succeeded to the throne as Czar (Emperor) in 1894, Russia was dangerously divided between the wealthy aristocracy and the discontented poor.

NICHOLAS II

Nicholas was an **autocrat**, believing that only he had the authority to rule Russia; however, he lacked the strength of will to fulfill this role. To remain a dominant European force, Russia desperately needed to industrialize, but with modernization came inevitable **demands for civil rights** from impoverished Russian workers. There were few freedoms for the predominantly peasant population. Nicholas, a natural conservative, repeatedly failed to work with moderate forces and reform society, losing the opportunity to transform Russia into a modern nation.

BOLSHEVIKS AND MENSHEVIKS

The **Russian Social Democratic Labor Party** (RSDLP) was formed in 1898, and was heavily

influenced by the theories of Karl Marx << 334–35. In 1902, the party divided into two strands; the **Bolsheviks**, led by Lenin (see right) who advocated change through violent

revolution, and the more moderate **Mensheviks**, who believed in a more gradual process of change.

RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR

In 1904 Russia became involved in a **war with the Japanese** over competing ambitions in Korea and Manchuria (northeast China) << 356–57. Weakened by successive defeats, Russia signed the **Treaty of Portsmouth** in 1905, bringing an end to the conflict.

1905 REVOLUTION

As Russia suffered defeats abroad, violence erupted at home. Petrograd (St. Petersburg) experienced a **brutal massacre** when 200,000 disaffected workers and their families **marched on the Winter Palace** (the residence of the czar) to demand better pay and working conditions. The protesters were met by Cossack cavalry who, sabers drawn, charged the crowd, killing many. Across Russia, the **population rose up** against the czar. Discipline broke down among troops and at Odessa, **sailors mutinied** against the appalling conditions on the battleship *Potemkin* (the subject of a 1925 film by Sergei Eisenstein).



JAPANESE WAR FLAG



POSTER FOR "BATTLESHIP POTECHKIN"



The Russian Revolution

Described by US journalist John Reed, a first-hand observer of the event, as “Ten Days That Shook the World,” the October Revolution of 1917 saw the Bolshevik Party seize power in Russia, after decades of discontent. The Bolsheviks went on to create the world’s first Communist state.

In the wake of the 1905 revolution (see BEFORE), Nicholas II agreed to instigate a new constitution for Russia, which included the formation of an elected parliament, or Duma. However, the czar retained the ability to disband the Duma at will, which he duly did when the assembly met in 1906 and 1907. Two subsequent Dumas met in 1907–1912 and 1912–17, although they were in almost constant conflict with Nicholas, who struggled to remain in control of the worsening political situation. The outbreak of World War I in August 1914 briefly united Russians against a common German enemy.

The war did not go well for Russia. By 1917, having sustained enormous losses on the battlefield and with the war effort creating high prices and food shortages, resentment toward the czar increased. Industrial workers across Russia began a crippling general strike. With violence erupting on the streets of

Petrograd and Moscow, Nicholas was finally forced to abdicate. The Duma handed over power to the Provisional Government, which aimed to establish a liberal democracy. But discontent was still in the air, as the government refused to withdraw from the war. The power was increasingly contested by the Petrograd Soviet of Workers and Soldiers, one of many workers’ councils (soviets) springing up all over the country. The Petrograd Soviet had the crucial support of troops garrisoned in the capital. It denounced the new government as “bourgeois” (middle class), and claimed to be the only true representative of the Russian people.

Peace, land, and bread

In April 1917, Lenin (see right), a key member of the revolutionary Russian Bolshevik Party, returned to Petrograd from exile in Western Europe. Lenin was convinced that collapse of world capitalism, as predicted by Karl Marx, was imminent. His aim was to

supervise a proletarian (workers’) revolution, with the rallying cry of “peace, land and bread, [and] all power to the Soviets.” In April the Bolshevik newspaper *Pravda* (“Truth”) published Lenin’s demands for the overthrow of the government and withdrawal from the “imperialist” war.

Lenin’s antiwar stance gained mass support in July, when a Russian offensive ended with huge casualties. For three days, soldiers and workers rioted in Petrograd in an uprising so damaging that the prime minister, Prince Lvov, resigned. He was replaced by Alexander Kerensky, who branded Lenin a German spy. Lenin fled to Finland and the prospect of revolution seemed to recede.

However, Lenin’s followers soon received assistance from an unlikely source. General Lavr Kornilov, the Russian army’s commander-in-chief, believed that the country would descend into anarchy if the Bolsheviks were to gain ground, and in August